

PARIS FRANCE

Marvelous Macarons in Paris

There's a lot to love about the French capital: temples of high art, sophisticated music haunts, cool *quartiers*, and lofty landmarks that span the centuries. But beyond the Louvre's masterpieces, Notre Dame's gargoyles, and the towering lights of the Eiffel Tower lies another tiny gem that never fails to draw crowds of Parisians and tourists: the perfect *macaron*.



An artistic city *par excellence*, Paris proffers an astonishing array of tempting pastimes. Culture vultures can swoop on highbrow opera and orchestral performances, or more

bohemian attractions such as art-house cinema and circuses. Myriad museums satisfy cravings for any and all types of painting, photography, installations, and sculpture, while city parks and gardens – such as the 17th-century Jardin du Luxembourg – provide the tranquillity in which to reflect on it.

Visitors can soak up the ambience of centuries past through the city's astonishing architecture, from the 12th-century Gothic masterpiece of Notre Dame to the Renaissance buildings of the Marais or the high-tech Pompidou Center. The shopping is just as extraordinary; Paris is arguably the fashion capital of the world, and an afternoon's shopping can easily encompass both the *haute couture* of rue du Faubourg Saint-Honoré and the flea-market finds of Saint-Ouen. And then there's the food – reason enough for a visit on its own. Not simply fuel, food is more fine art here,

and nowhere is that better illustrated than in Paris patisseries. The most French of fancies – the *macaron* – is a byword for pastry perfection.

Henri II's Italian wife, Catherine de Medici, is credited with bringing the meringue to France in 1533, but it was a Frenchman, Pierre Desfontaines – cousin of Paris tea-salon owner Louis Ernest Ladurée (see right) – who first hit upon the idea, in the early 20th century, of joining two *macarons* together with a blob of chocolate ganache. Like all things painfully delicious, this ensemble requires real finesse. The ingredients are simple: egg whites, ground almonds, sugar, and flavoring. But it's the sifting, folding in, piping, letting them sit (or not), and baking at just the right temperature that determines whether they achieve that perfect crust and glossy dome. And it's the combination of chewy meringue and velvety center that causes people to sigh as they bite into ivory buttons oozing salted caramel, baby-pink disks encasing rose petals, or snowy puffs cloaking hazelnut and white truffle. Some connoisseurs insist they taste better the day after they're made, but who has the steely nerve to wait that long?



Above An alfresco café in the formal gardens of the Jardin du Luxembourg



The Best Places to Eat Macarons

Pierre Hermé expensive

Fourth-generation pastry-maker Pierre Hermé is the resident *macaron* magician, conjuring up creations that people cross town for. Hermé claims he only makes "what feels right" when it comes to these jewel-box disks, and there's no denying his surefire instincts. That crunchy shell and those creamy flavors: vanilla and olive oil, crème brûlée, wasabi and strawberry, and quince and rose are all life-enhancing combinations. Hermé started his career at the age of 14, when he was apprenticed to the famed *pâtissier* Gaston Lenôte, and was head of the pastry kitchen at esteemed patisserie Fauchon by the time he was 24. Hermé now has his own sweet empire with four boutiques in Paris: those in rue Bonaparte and rue de Vaugirard showcase his complete range of pastry pleasures, while those in rue Cambon and Avenue Paul Doumer concentrate solely on *macarons* and chocolates. It's worth making a pilgrimage to one of his two pastry shops in summer, when raspberries are in season, just to try "Ispahan" – two large rose-flavored *macarons* sandwiching rose petal cream, whole raspberries, and lychees. Ladurée may have invented the *macaron* but Pierre Hermé, dubbed "the Picasso of Pastry," perfected it.

4 rue Cambon and 58 Avenue Paul Doumer, Paris; open 10 AM–7 PM daily; www.pierreherme.com

Also in Paris

Ladurée, on rue Royale (www.laduree.fr; **expensive**), draws a constant stream of customers, lured by the unchanged, old-world interior and the delicious, ever-changing window displays: *croquebouches* made of rainbow *macarons*, *macaron* stacks anointed with papery butterflies, and tiers of pastel-colored *macaron* boxes lashed with ribbons. While Pierre Hermé (see above) opts for daring pairings, Ladurée turns out timeless classics: chocolate, vanilla, pistachio, orange blossom, lemon, and seasonal specials. There are other Paris branches, but this one is precious.

Also in France

Gastronomic Lyon has its own *macaron* masters. **Sève** (www.chocolatseve.com; **expensive**) dishes up to-die-for apple *tatin macarons* and savory domes filled with sesame and Gorgonzola, while **Sébastien Bouillet** (www.chocolatier-bouillet.com; **moderate**) dreams up fairy-floss *macarons* and salted caramel in a chocolate shell flaked with gold leaf.

Around the World

Pierre Hermé's **Aoyama** boutique (+81 3 5485 7766; **expensive**) in Tokyo was his first shop. The first floor is devoted to display, while upstairs in the Bar Chocolat, you can nibble on chocolates, pastries, and *macarons*.

Cooking Classes

There's no better place to learn the art of patisserie than in Paris. There are half-day, full-day, and multi-day courses, usually for 3–6 people. All the courses here need to be booked ahead. At **Promenades Gourmandes** (www.promenadesgourmandes.com), pastry and *macaron* master Joël Morgeat imparts an infallible technique for turning out perfect little meringue domes of chocolate, raspberry, or grapefruit, under the watchful eye of Parisian gourmet Paule Caillat. **Ecole Ritz Escoffier**, in the Ritz Hotel (www.ritzparis.com), runs classes showing how to whip up *macarons* in many flavors; expect to learn one flavor in 2 hours, or several in a 4-hour class. **La Cuisine Paris** (www.lacuisineparis.com) runs afternoon *macaron*-making classes in both French and English in the center of Paris.